Cloudscaler

THE SUSTAINABLE FINANCE LIVE HACKATHON

Your AWS credits

How much you have, how to use it, and how to make it last until demo time.

aws PARTNER Advanced Tier Services

$400

AWS credit per team

Each team gets its own AWS account with **$400** of credit to spend during the hackathon.

When your account reaches $400, it is locked. You lose access to the console and your running resources — there is no top-up. Plan to finish with credit to spare.

Billing data lags Cost Explorer can be up to 24 hours behind real spend. What you see is lower than what you have used. Treat **$300** as your working limit.

Getting started

1. Sign in with SSO through the IAM Identity Center access portal: https://d-9c67b461bd.awsapps.com/start/
2. Work in eu-west-2 and us-east-1. Other regions are blocked.
3. Create an AWS Budgets alert at $200 and $275 so the team gets an email before it matters.
4. Tag everything with `team` and `owner` so you can find what to delete.
5. Check Billing → Cost Explorer at the start and end of each day.

What burns credits fast

- **Premium GenAI Models** — Fable 5.1 costs 100 times more than Haiku 5.5. Build with smaller models and upgrade only where needed.
- **Sending large datasets to models** — every token you send is billed. Send only the data you need, not whole datasets.
- **GPU and large EC2 instances** — some cost more than $30 an hour.
- **Networking that bills hourly** — NAT Gateways, Transit Gateway attachments, Network Firewall and interface VPC endpoints charge per hour, per AZ, before any traffic.
- **Clusters and databases** — EKS control planes, RDS, OpenSearch and MSK charge whether used or not.
- **Multi-AZ by default** — three AZs triples the hourly cost. One or two is enough for a demo.
- **Marketplace subscriptions** — usually not covered by credits.

Make it last

- Default to serverless — Lambda, API Gateway, S3, DynamoDB on-demand. They cost nothing when idle.
- If you need a server, start small (t4g / t3) and scale only when you have to.
- Run EKS or ECS on Fargate or small Spot nodes, and scale node groups to zero when idle.
- Test pipelines and IaC changes against one account and one AZ before fanning out.
- Deploy with IaC (CDK, Terraform, SAM) so tearing down and rebuilding takes one command.

Working in our landing zone

- Logging, CloudTrail and security tooling are already run centrally. Don't switch on extra trails, Config recorders, GuardDuty or Security Hub — they add cost and duplicate what exists.
- Use the VPC provided. Building your own with NAT Gateways costs money from the first hour.
- Guardrails block some services and instance types. If something is denied, it is by design — ask before working around it.

End of every day

Stop or delete instances, clusters and NAT Gateways. Check Cost Explorer. Anything left running overnight bills while you sleep.

After the hackathon

Accounts will be rolled off. Speak to your team lead about timings, and export any code or data you want to keep before then.

Need help?

Account locked, spend looks wrong, or need a blocked service? Contact Danyal Hussain at **Danyal.hussain@cloudscaler.com**.